Edward VII School (KES) in Johannesburg. For Faf, me and a few others, these would be our last matches for Affies.

'AB, you may have to miss the next two matches.'

Deon Botes had called me aside and explained that the Northerns selectors had chosen me to play in the provincial B team final against Western Province B in Cape Town. That was exciting news, but I was torn.

'To be honest, sir,' I replied, 'I would rather finish our season with my friends.'

'Are you sure? This is a great opportunity.'

'I know, sir, but I don't want to miss the matches against Boys' High and KES.'

The Northerns selectors were duly informed I was unavailable for the B team final but my decision didn't look so great when, in the match against Boys' High, I was out for a duck before the rain began to fall. Play was abandoned but Mr Botes and his counterpart agreed that the match would be replayed a week later.

So we travelled to play KES. They had a talented team that included captain Blake Snijman and Vaughn van Jaarsveld, both of whom would later play provincial cricket, and a tight match came down to the last over, with KES needing three runs to win with one wicket standing and two balls remaining. The batsman swung, sending the ball high in the air. I started running away from the wicket, getting under the ball to take the catch and win the match … watching the ball over my shoulder, running hard … watching the ball, stretching out my arms … and dropping the catch.

My heart sank. The moment still ranks among the greatest disappointments of my career. The batsmen had run two and, off the last ball, the KES batsman tapped and ran the single required for victory.

The replayed match against Boys' High followed a few days later and I was determined to make amends. After anxiously surviving an early